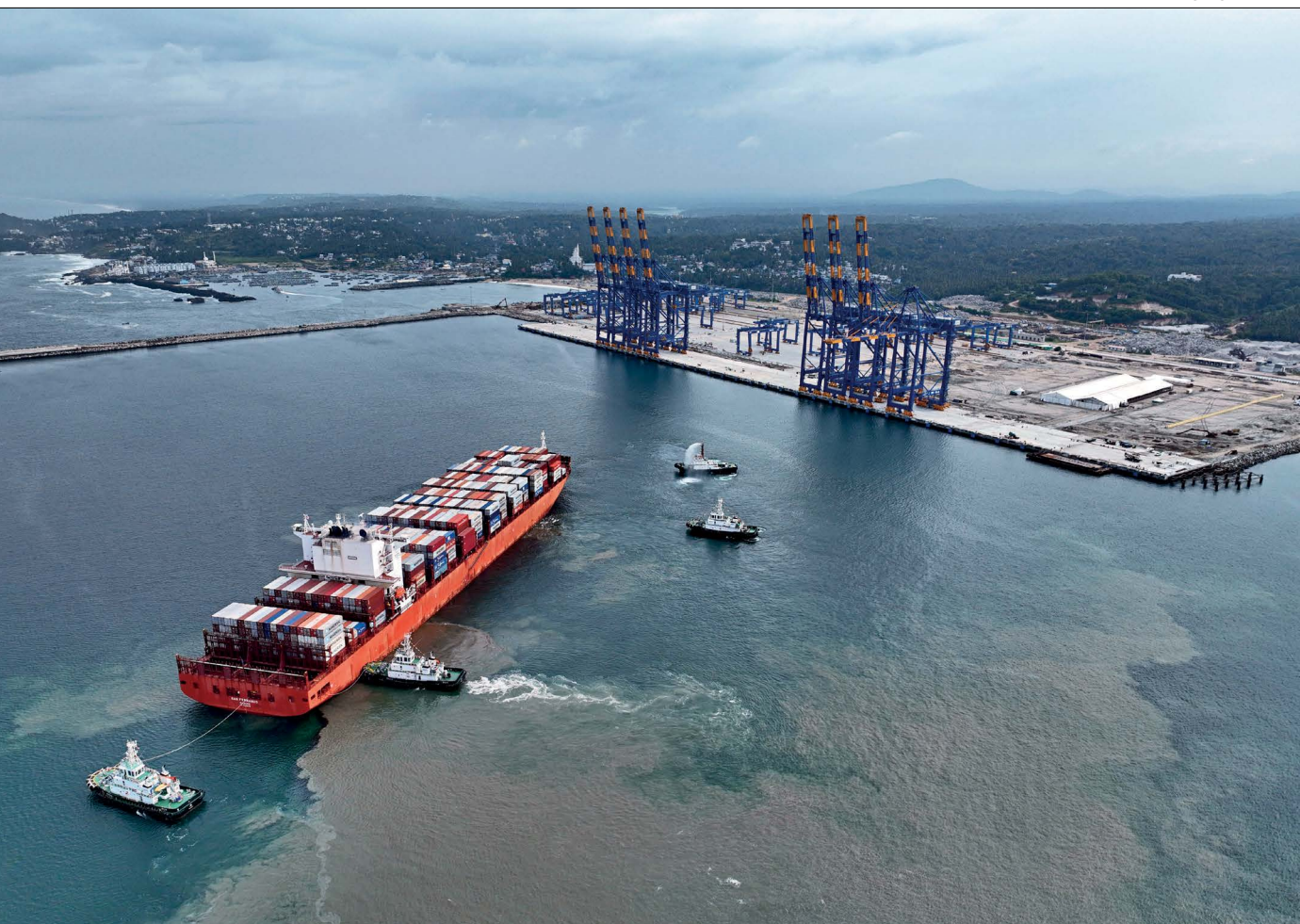




The Vizhinjam International Seaport, in Thiruvananthapuram

to the US Energy Information Administration.

Speaking at the *BT* Mindrush in March this year, Indian Navy Chief Admiral Swaminathan said that India is a maritime nation straddling the Indian Ocean, where much of the world's international trade passes and key trade lanes crisscross.

“Inimical countries or mountain ranges block our linkages to the north. We are crucially dependent on the sea for economic well-being. Sea lanes are important for strategic stability. Safety and

stability at sea cannot be taken for granted. Sea lanes and security of sea lanes—if they are threatened by any conflict, there will be spill-over effects,” said Swaminathan.

Experts further point out that nearly 80% of China's oil imports and a significant share of its cargo pass through the Malacca Strait. “India requires a strong economic and military base in Great Nicobar amid China's growing naval presence in the Indian Ocean Region,” says former Air Chief Marshal RKS Bhadauria.

The island's strategic location

near the Malacca Strait is a choke-point after the Strait of Hormuz.

COMPETITIVENESS

Ports such as Vizhinjam, Visakhapatnam and Vadhavan are also targeting transshipment traffic. The Department of Economic Affairs (DEA), during a meeting of the Public Private Partnership Appraisal Committee (PPPAC), flagged whether Galathea Bay will compete with these projects.

The document accessed by *BT* of the PPPAC appraisal meeting held on March 19 this year shows